

ARGOSY



MAY
4

ALL-STORY WEEKLY

10¢

In Canada
15¢



Swords Are Out!

Stirring Adventure in China

By W. Wirt

Charles Alden Seltzer - Talbot Mundy
Victor Rousseau - Lieut. John Hopper

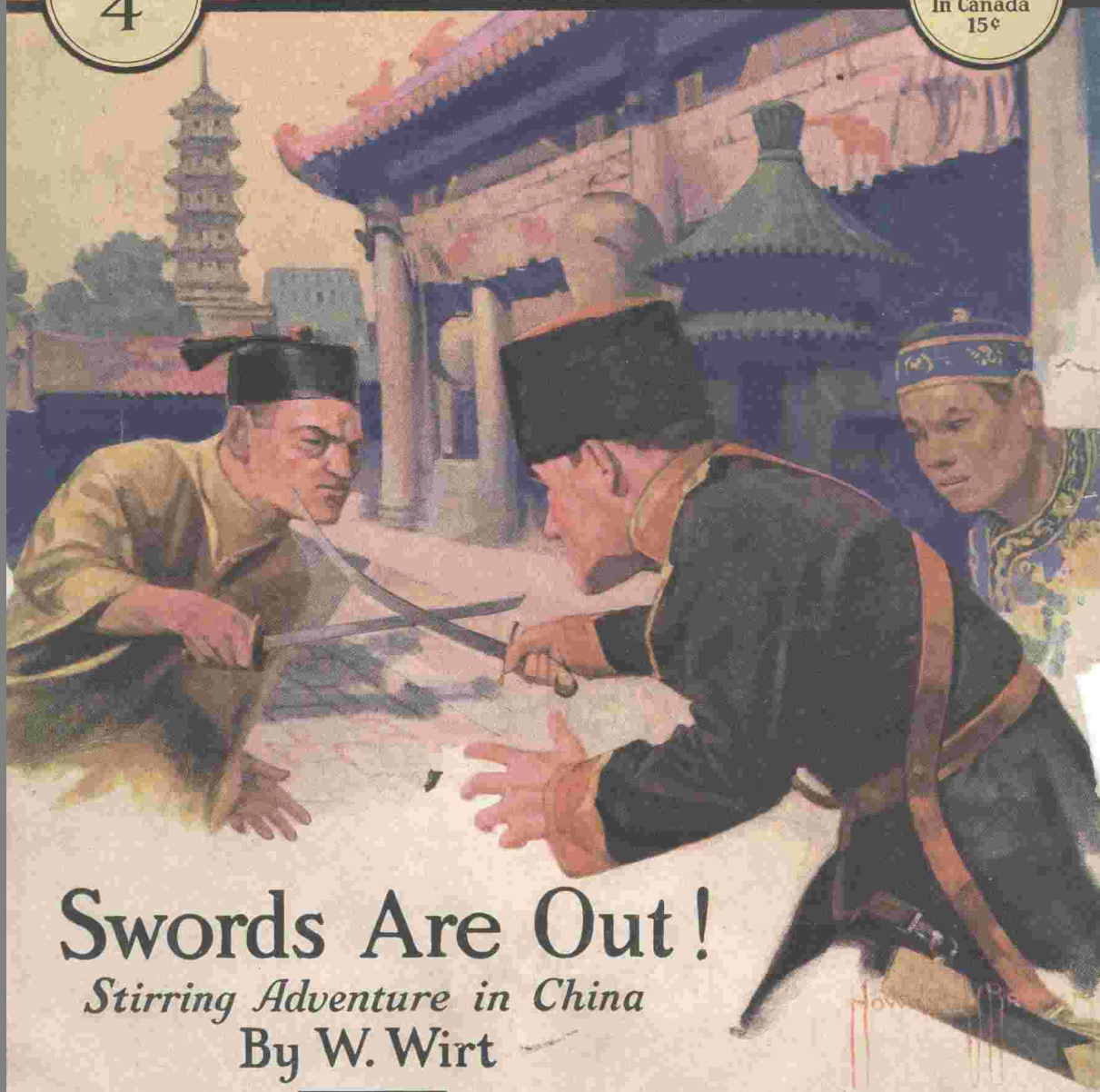
ARGOSY

ALL-STORY WEEKLY

MAY
4

10¢

In Canada
15¢



Swords Are Out!

Stirring Adventure in China

By W. Wirt

Charles Alden Seltzer - Talbot Mundy

Victor Rousseau - Lieut. John Hopper

The Project Gutenberg eBook of No stop-overs

This eBook is for the use of anyone anywhere in the United States and most other parts of the world at no cost and with almost no restrictions whatsoever. You may copy it, give it away or re-use it under the terms of the Project Gutenberg License included with this eBook or online at www.gutenberg.org. If you are not located in the United States, you will have to check the laws of the country where you are located before using this eBook.

Title: No stop-overs

Author: John A. Thompson

Release date: April 19, 2025 [eBook #75913]

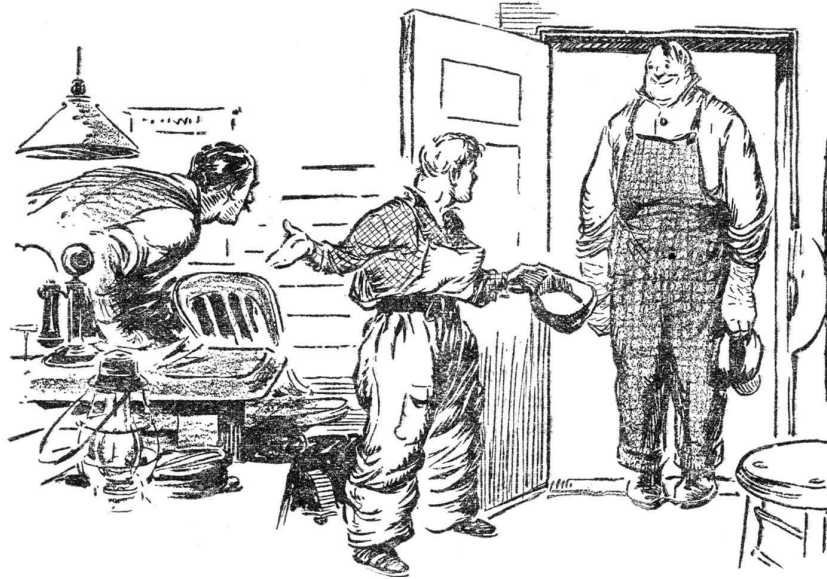
Language: English

Original publication: New York, NY: Frank A. Munsey Company, 1929

Other information and formats: www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/75913

Credits: Roger Frank and Sue Clark

***** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK NO STOP-
OVERS *****



*The doorway was filled by a great mass of brawn and muscle, grinning
from ear to ear*

NO STOP-OVERS

By John A. Thompson

With the lure of the gold camps taking every able-bodied man from his job, you can't keep a good man on in Alaska railroading—but Sam Tebbetts and Plapp were exceptional.

Because of the boom out at the gold diggings on the Kougarok, the little railroad that wound its way through brush and over tundra from Nome to the up-country mining camps had an unusually heavy spring traffic to handle. The sudden brisk business was profitable. But it meant more trains. More trains meant more locomotive engineers—engine drivers, they call them nowadays—and men who could drive an old Forney type, or a 4-4-0 American, were scarce in Alaska.

In this emergency, firemen were given regular runs. Every call boy and roundhouse sweeper husky enough to lift a slice bar was set to work firing. Still the road was short-handed.

The new engineers had a disconcerting habit of deserting. The minute they pulled into the terminal yards up on the Kougarok, they would steal a pick and shovel from the maintenance department and duck out for the gold-bearing creeks two miles out of town. One absconding brakeman had

the brass to stake out his mining claim with signal flags swiped from the road before he left.

Worried over operating conditions, haggard from loss of sleep, the general superintendent bent over the morning reports in his office down at Nome. Suddenly he looked up as the door opened a few inches. One of the oddest specimens of humanity he had ever cast eyes on sidled through the narrow aperture, and coughed to attract attention.

For ten silent seconds the super stared at the man in amazement. The stranger was less than pint size. Yet he wore overalls that had obviously been made for a man of generous architecture. His trouser legs were rolled into bulky cuffs almost knee-high, and a broad leather belt around his waist gave him more or less indefinite control over the slack in his stern-sheets.

For all the tiny man's incongruous get-up, however, there was a firm set to his square, pugnacious chin and determination in the large gray eyes that peered out from under his bushy thatch of straw-colored hair.

"Ahem!" The stranger coughed again.

"Well," snapped the super, "what do you want? Do you work on this road?"

The stranger shuffled toward the super's desk.

"Not yet," he said cheerily, answering the last question first. "Hope to soon, sir. Name is Tebbetts, Sam Tebbetts. Glad to meet you. Press the flesh."

Sam thrust out his hand. Before the super realized what he was doing he had stood up and shaken hands with the man. Almost instantly he sat down again with uncomfortable abruptness, angry at himself and the smiling stranger.

"If it's a job you're looking for, I'm not the man you want to see. I don't hire the bohunks."

"Sam Tebbetts ain't no bohunk, mister." Sam bristled like a fighting cock and there was an unexpected quality in his voice that made the super sit upright. "He's an engineer."

It was the first time in three weeks that the super had had a really good laugh for himself. He leaned back in his chair and rocked with merriment.

“A what? An engineer? You? Ho-ho-ho!”

Sam flushed crimson as he dug down deep into a back pocket and pulled forth a packet of thumb-marked credentials which he flung angrily on the desk in front of the super.

“Sam Tebbetts ain’t no liar, either,” he declared.

The super picked up the papers and began studying them with growing interest. Evidently the man was right. He was an engineer; a good one too.

“What did you come up to Nome for?” asked the super, suspicious still of the comic strip character that had walked into his office.

“To go gold minin’,” answered Sam promptly.

“I thought so.” The super sighed. “If it’s just free transportation to the Kougarok that you are looking for, I’ll write you out a pass. It’s easier in the end. I’m through hiring drifters that take a run or two and then jump the train at the other end of the line. Seven engineers have deserted me this week.”

“Sam Tebbetts ain’t that kind.”

The super grunted. He was still doubtful of this shock-headed lad, but he needed men badly. “The crowd up here is pretty rough. Apt to rag hell out of you.”

“Guess I can take care of myself.” Sam stuck out his jaw and clenched his fists, following which demonstration of belligerency he shadow-boxed around the super’s desk for a few seconds. He wound up the demonstration with a vicious uppercut to the empty air.

“When do I start?”

“Mr. Tebbetts,” said the super calmly, “I’ll start you right now—but only if you’ll agree to stick with the road all season. Your wages will be paid when we close down for the winter. In the meantime I’ll see that your food and board bills are taken care of.”

“Suits me,” said Sam. “Press the flesh.”

This time the super declined the proffered hand. With a wave of his hand he indicated that he considered the matter closed.

“Ahem!” Sam coughed again.

“Well! It’s all right ahead. Go ahead down to the roundhouse. You’re hired, Mr. Tebbetts.”

“Yes, sir. But I’d like a job for my pal too. He’s a fireman. Fired for me eight years, sir. Good man. Dutch. Steady worker. Name’s Plapp. Suydam Plapp.”

“Well, where is he?” The super looked about the office in astonishment.

“He’s here,” said Sam. “Plapp! Hey, Plapp! Come on in. Meet the super. He’s regular. We got a job, Plapp.”

Again the office door opened quietly and this time the doorway was filled by a great mass of brawn and muscle, grinning from ear to ear.

“Is that Plapp?” asked the super.

“Yes, sir. And, mister, if all firemen was as good as him, the people that makes mechanical stokers would go out of business in a week.”

“Hmm. He looks like Zbysko. Remember, he goes to work under the same conditions that you do, Tebbetts.”

“Suits us.” Tebbetts pushed his big companion toward the door. “Let’s go down to the roundhouse, Plapp, and meet the gang.”

When they had closed the door after them, the super pulled out a handkerchief and mopped his face. “Phew,” he muttered, “if the road don’t go plumb to pot with that team o’ galoots workin’ on it, I’m crazy. Lucky for them they hit me when I was short-handed.”

The super had barely settled down to resumption of his morning’s work when the roundhouse foreman and a man from the dispatcher’s office rushed into this sanctum within ten seconds of each other, each with the same breathless request.

“Any more medical stores up here? Liniment, gauze bandages, sticking plaster?”

“What’s the matter?” exclaimed the super. “An accident?”

“No, sir.” It was the roundhouse foreman who found his tongue first. “Jest them two circus freaks you sent down this mornin’. One of the boys started kidding the little fellow.”

“I warned him it was a rough crowd,” said the super.

“Warned him!” The foreman’s voice rose. “He don’t need no warnin’. Swung right at the lad that was kiddin’ him, and then he yells, ‘Plapp! Hey, Plapp!’ and the big Dutchman comes a runnin’. ‘Hold him, Sam!’ roars the

big fellow, 'Don't let him get away, the bully. Pickin' on a little runt like you.'"

"Hmm," muttered the superintendent. "We've got enough trouble without a lot of senseless scrapping among the men. Tell those two I don't want any more of it. And take them some first aid stuff. It's in the cabinet there."

"It ain't them that wants it, sir. It's my man. You can pour most of what's left of him in a coal oil can." The foreman shook his head sadly. He walked toward the cabinet at the open end of the office and the super turned on the clerk from the dispatcher's office.

"Well, what's your trouble?" he demanded.

"It's those two new fellows." The clerk spoke timidly.

"What about them? Speak up."

"T-T-Tebbetts came in for his orders and we all started to laugh. He looked so funny in those big pants, and Thonet was at his key and he turned around and said to Tebbetts—"

"Never mind what he said. What happened?"

"Well, they exchanged words and then Tebbetts made a pass at Thonet and caught him behind the ear with a fist like a mallet and when we tried to pull him away he yelled for Plapp."

The super smiled in spite of himself. "Then what?"

"The boys downstairs want some gauze and some liniment and some—"

"Get out of here!" thundered the super. "It looks as if you fellows were picking on the wrong dog this time."

"Yes, sir," agreed the retreating clerk. "Anyhow, we've got most of the broken chairs picked up and we're straightening up the office, while Thonet is getting his wires in order again. Plapp ripped them out."

As the clerk left, the super called to the foreman, whose arms were laden with bottles and bandages.

"What's the matter with those two, Jim? Just quarrelsome?"

"No. I wouldn't say that," replied the foreman. "They wait for the other fellows to start something, but they sure do love a scrap."

"Outside of that, do they know their business? What is that big fellow Plapp? He seems to do most of the damage. Is he a fireman, a ruffian, or only another disappointed white hope?"

“He’s a fireman all right. In fact both of ’em seems to know their jobs.”

“Where are they now?”

“Plapp and the runt are out with No. 57.”

“Hmm. Get her out all right? Gave the big boy a tough engine to fire on his first run, didn’t they?”

The foreman smiled. “Break ’em in right. On account o’ bein’ short o’ yard help, Plapp gets No. 57 cold. By about the time an ordinary cuss would have them boilers warm, I heard a crack and a sizzle and when I look out there’s No. 57 poppin’ off like she’s goin’ to blow herself apart. Plapp, grimy and smilin’, is standin’ in the cab. He has his sleeves rolled up and he looks like he was goin’ to pick his teeth with the slice bar he’s playin’ with.” He paused.

“Go ahead,” said the super, “I want to know how No. 57 got away on time for the first time in three weeks.”

“Well, I see little Sam Tebbetts come runnin’ acrost the tracks, chipper as hell, ’cept when he comes near trippin’ on his nose and his shoes get caught in those sea-goin’ pants. He swings into the cab, talks to Plapp for a few seconds. Then he looks at his watch and the two shake hands. The next minute Tebbetts is on the engineer’s seat box. I see he can hardly stretch up to some o’ the valves without standin’ up. But he tries the air, opens the cylinder cocks, eases open on his throttle and old No. 57 wheezes down the rails as pretty as you please.”

The super, palms outstretched on the top of his desk, tapped his index fingers thoughtfully. “Well, I’d advise you fellows against trying to kid Tebbetts. It doesn’t seem to pay.”

“No, sir, it don’t.”

“And,” added the super, “when you go past the dispatcher’s office tell them I want them to keep me posted on No. 57’s run till she lands up at the Kougarok terminus.”

By evening the superintendent began to think he had done a clever stroke of business in hiring Tebbetts and Plapp. In front of him was a long train sheet and he gazed in quiet satisfaction at the run of fast freight No. 57. She was checked off “on time” all down the line and at every meet and was

reported as pulling into Kougarok yards twenty-six seconds ahead of schedule.

The run from Nome to the Kougarok is only about a hundred miles. In the morning, after three scraps and one minor riot with a gang of prospectors, Sam Tebbetts and Plapp marked up for a trip back to town. They were given No. 12, with a string of empties to be rolled into the freight yards at Nome.

Sam was delayed by a brief passage of arms with the Kougarok dispatcher, whom he advised to let somebody wash his ears and make a good job of it. Then turning a deaf ear to an impassioned request for a lock of his hair to patch the station doormat with, he bolted for his engine, stuffing his orders into his pocket as he ran.

He stumbled up into the cab, tripped over a coal shovel, and would have pitched himself through the open firebox door, had not Plapp reached out a strong hand and jerked him back by the seat of his pants.

“It’s a wonder to me, Sam,” said Plapp, talking like a father to an errant offspring, “that you wouldn’t buy yourself a set o’ overalls o’ your own, instead of wearin’ mine.”

Sam made a face like a man with a mouthful of hair and started down the tracks with a jerk. “If you’d keep them shovels and truck off the floor plates, an engineer could come aboard his own cab without breakin’ his neck,” he snorted.

Tebbetts rattled across the yard switches and out onto the single track main line. There was a down grade with a few curves in it for the first few miles and Sam let his empties breeze along at a fast clip.

For awhile he and Plapp said nothing to each other. Sam pulled his train-order flimsy from his pocket and reread it for certainty’s sake. “I see,” he said, turning to Plapp who was staring idly out the left-hand window, “where we got a lot o’ meets this run. Ptarmigan Gulch, Moonglow, the turn-out by Cooley’s Bend. Mostly passenger trains comin’ up, too. Them miners sure are pilin’ into the Kougarok country.”

“Yeh,” assented Plapp truculently. “an’ I thought we come up here to find us a gold mine. The first thing you do like a bone-dome is get us a job with a contract where we can’t quit to go prospectin’. What a fine bowl o’ tripe your brains turned out to be!”

“We’ll get our prospectin’ in. Trust Sam Tebbetts an’ don’t act like a sorehead.” Sam was going to say more. But his body suddenly stiffened and in his excitement he yelled for Plapp. The fireman came over to the engineer’s side of the cab. “Look! What does that look like to you? Gold, ain’t it?” Tebbetts was pointing to several boulders lying on the hillside. Bright specks in the rocks glistened beneath the rays of the morning sun.

“Mebbe them shiny bits is gold,” agreed Plapp. “They’re yellow.”

“Yea, Plapp! We’re millionaires!” shouted Sam, closing his throttle. There was an ear-rending bangety-clank as the engineer jammed on his air brakes. The empties rocked and cascaded to an abrupt stop. Sam leaped from the cab and, with one hand holding his trousers up, sprinted for the nearest boulder. Plapp followed, a fair imitation of an elephant in full flight.

Back in the caboose a startled conductor and a brakeman found their quiet game of casino rudely interrupted. They dashed for the rear platform together, wondering what was up. No. 12 was as still as an empty tomb, motionless as the hills themselves. And there was no signal set against her, nor could another train be heard thundering toward her on the single track. The brakeman tilted his cap on the back of his head.

“What the hell!” he muttered.

“There they are!” The conductor spotted the running pair first. “Look! The big fella’ is chasin’ the little one down the hill. Wonder what happened.” He beckoned to the brakeman. “Take the flags and go on back along the track in case somethin’ may be comin’ along. I’ll go down and see what the trouble is.”

The conductor caught up with Sam and Plapp when they stopped beside one of the boulders. The two were in the midst of an argument when he arrived.

“Well, it’s yellow, ain’t it? And it shines, don’t it? How do you know it ain’t gold?” said Sam.

“Yeh,” said Plapp, still unconvinced, “but—”

“But, me eye! Hey, conductor, look what we found. Gold! Plapp and me are rich. We’re all rich. Press the flesh.” Sam put forth his hand, but the conductor remained unreceptive to the suggestion.

“What’s the matter with you guys? Crazy? That ain’t gold, it’s yellow mica. See?” The conductor pried some of the glittering mineral from the rock and split it into small, thin leaves with his thumb nail.

“Yep. It’s mica,” said Sam crestfallen. “Sorry, boys, my mistake.”

However, the conductor wasn’t through. He turned on Sam angrily. “What’s the idea of stopping your train like that?”

“Who wants to know?” Sam thrust forth his chin temptingly and the conductor landed one on the button that sent the little man reeling to the ground.

“Plapp! Hey, Plapp!” moaned Sam. “You seen him hit me. Where are you? Lettin’ that guy hit a little fella like me.”

Plapp studied the situation for a solemn moment. “You told me that stuff was gold,” he said slowly to Sam. “You had it comin’ for lyin’ to me thataways.” Then he turned toward the conductor and the light of battle suddenly blazed in his eyes. “Still an’ all, it’s a hell of a thing to hit a little runt like Sam so hard as you did, you big bum.” He stepped up close to the conductor.

Still rubbing his chin, Sam sat up to watch the fray and give some unnecessary advice to Plapp. In spite of his size, Plapp, once he was aroused, swung his fists as fast as greased lightning. He could handle his dukes like a professional. And he believed in making his battles as brief as possible.

Sam helped Plapp drag the wilted form of the conductor back to the train. They called in the brakeman, stowed the conductor in the caboose, and having suggested that a little raw beef would take the swelling out of his fast closing left eye, went forward and climbed into the engine cab together.

That was the beginning of Sam’s wayside prospecting. Seven times on the trip to Nome he pulled up his train with a jerk and cut wildly across the scenery, followed by the faithful Plapp. Five times investigation proved that it was mica that had misled him. Twice chunks of the brassy iron pyrites caught his eye.

Sam rocked into his destination two hours late. Moreover, his loitering had made him late at several meets and as a result the northbound schedule of trains to the Kougarok had been seriously disturbed. All along the line, the road cursed No. 12.

“Great stuff, prospectin’, hey, Plapp?” Sam slapped the fireman on the back. It was like slapping a barn door made of solid oak. “Of course you can’t expect to strike it rich the first day. But I’m goin’ to buy me a gold pan to-night. We’ll do the country proper to-morrow.”

“But the train?”

“We ain’t quittin’, are we? Just pausin’ on our way. No harm in that, is there? Say, I been held up for hours at a time, lots o’ times, by the operating department. Anyhow, we come to Alaska to go prospectin’, and we’re goin’ to do it, ain’t we?”

Plapp nodded. Sam stuck out his hand. “Press the flesh, kid.” The little man and his big companion struck out across the tracks for a lunch wagon with the sign “Eat” displayed in large letters over the center sliding door.

For a week Sam prospected on the fly and ran his trains late. Only the road’s extreme need of men enabled him to hold his job. He was called in and bawled out by everybody from the old man himself on down. He was threatened. He was pleaded with. It was no use. Sam had set his heart on prospecting.

The general superintendent sent for Tebbetts one morning. Aside from his loitering by the wayside to go gold hunting, Sam was a good engineer. The super could ill afford to lose him. “Tebbetts,” he said sharply, “this independent prospecting of yours is throwing the operation of the line all out of plumb. I won’t have it. I want you to stop it.”

“Well, I ain’t quit and left you stranded with a train up at the Kougarok, like Bennett did last night, have I?” said Sam defensively. “Me and Plapp has got a claim staked just off the switch at Cooley’s Bend. A good one too. But we ain’t quit you. Tebbetts’ll stick by his word.”

The super’s face brightened. He decided to play up to Sam’s hair-trigger sense of honor.

“Yes. I believe you will, Tebbetts. You’re a man of your word. I can trust you. I’m going to take you off the freight runs and give you passengers. The responsibility for the lives of many men.”

“Yes, sir.”

“The accident hazard isn’t any greater. But a freight smash-up and a passenger wreck are two entirely different things. You understand that, of

course.”

“Yes, sir.”

“Good. I’m putting you on your honor now, Tebbetts. This is a personal matter between you and me. I want you to promise that you won’t make a single stop that isn’t on your orders. Remember, Tebbetts, you’re going to carry passengers. No stop-overs to go prospecting, or daisy-picking, or anything else.”

The super’s system worked. Sam was as good as his word. He ran his passengers to and from the Kougarok regularly. They kept him busy.

Plenty of overtime, but no time off. It wasn’t easy for Sam to work faithfully with the gold fever burning his heart out. Day or night, the moment he climbed out of his cab, the only thing he thought about was the claim he and Plapp had staked not far from the switch at Cooley’s Bend.

There were times when he regretted his promise to the superintendent. However, having given his word, his word held him to his duty.

“Aw, Sam, what’s the use?” suggested Plapp one morning as they were running down the grades to Nome. “You’re gettin’ into a fog broodin’. Let’s quit and try out our claim.”

“Can’t,” said Tebbetts quietly. “Told the super I wouldn’t run out on him. You and me are about the only regulars left now.”

“Don’t I know it,” went on Plapp. “The others are all quittin’ and gettin’ rich. Smith and McDobbs and Koebel and—”

“Mebbe they are,” snapped Sam. “But Tebbetts ain’t. You go ahead if you want to quit.”

“Naw. Guess I’ll stick, if you do,” replied Plapp.

A few days later Sam marked up for the Nome express as usual. He was up at the Kougarok end of the line and he felt nervous. The proximity of the boom diggings always made him feel worse at the Kougarok. The strain of his continued loyalty was beginning to show in dark crow’s feet under his eyes and the taut lines about his mouth.

He started out of the station without waiting for the conductor’s highball. The latter dashed out of the depot and caught the last coach. Two sharp yanks on the whistle cord brought Sam to a quick stop three hundred feet down the track. The conductor ran along the roadbed till he was opposite

the engine cab, and for the first time in his life Sam took a calling down without making a single comeback.

“What’s the matter, Sam,” asked Plapp as the Nome express gathered headway again, “sick? Or just thinkin’ that mebbe we’re a couple o’ potential millionaires and don’t know it, workin’ our hearts out on a railroad?”

“Aw hell, if there’s gold in that ground of ours, it’ll stay there till we get it. It ain’t goin’ to fly away,” said Sam, trying to fight down his desire to go back on his word and quit.

He was still debating the question within his mind when he pulled into Ptarmigan Gulch and he almost forgot that he had a meet there with a northbound freight. He ran past a signal set dead against him and only pulled up to a short stop when Plapp yelled at him. When the freight had gone by, he rattled out of the Gulch in the same nervous hurry that marked his departure from the Kougarok depot.

As he approached the switch at Cooley’s Bend, he took a last good look down the track ahead of him and then closed his eyes going by the gravel-bottomed gully in which lay the little stretch of auriferous earth that held his fondest dreams of wealth and fortune.

The claim lay up the gully a short distance to the right. Plapp had the firebox door open and was about to heave some coal into his glowing furnaces when he chanced to look over toward the property he and Sam had staked. For a half second he held his shovel poised in mid-air. Then he dropped it with a clatter to the floor, and shook Sam excitedly.

“Sam, look! Look! There’s men on our claim. Workin’—diggin’ gold out of it! Sam, they’re robbin’ us.”

Sam opened his eyes with a start. “The dirty buzzards!” he yelled. Just ahead of him, he saw the turn-out. His passengers, his given word, everything seemed of little importance beside the fact that men were on his claim, stealing from him. He shut his throttle on the thread of steam and applied his brakes.

“Jump, Plapp!” he shouted as the speeding train came to a grinding halt. “Run ahead and throw that switch. I’m gonna take the express out on that siding till we clean them lousy crooks off our property.”

Plapp jumped, rolled over in the ditch once, then picked himself up and ran for the switch. He threw the bar over as Sam released his brakes and opened his throttle gently. Once across the switch the engineer shut off steam again and let his train coast to a stop, while he swung out of the cab.

Passengers stuck their heads out of the windows. The conductor came running toward Sam, but before he could get breath enough to open his mouth Sam called to him.

“Hey, throw that switch back on the main line! Me and Plapp will be back in a couple of minutes.”

With that he dashed up the gully after Plapp. There were three men working on the claim.

“Hey!” shouted the big fireman. “What’s the idea, you dirty thieves, stealin’ a man’s gold!”

The biggest of the three men, a great black-bearded fellow, spat contemptuously. “Yuh ain’t referrin’ to me and my pardners, is you, stranger? ’Cause I got a notion to make you eat them words, handsome.”

“The hell we ain’t!” shouted Sam, coming up with the group. “Sock him, Plapp! He’s your size. Bust him on the nose!”

Plapp’s fist shot out at the same time the big claim-jumper reached for his gun. There was the crack of knotted fist on a jawbone and the sharp bang-bang of gunfire.

“He’s tryin’ to shoot you! The yellow skunk!” screamed Sam, jumping for the man with the gun. As he plunged, the other two claim-jumpers swung into the melee. One tripped Sam with his foot and the other dealt his falling body a vicious blow with his fist. Sam rolled to the ground, but he managed to get his arms around a leg of the big miner. He clung like a leech as the man tried to shake himself free.

With a howl of rage and pain the claim-jumper bent over to finish off the engineer. Plapp caught the miner a stomach blow that doubled him up. Unfortunately the force of his follow through took the fireman off his balance. He fell on top of the jumper and Sam on the bottom of the pile felt his head being ground into the dirt and gravel by the weight of the two heavy men on top of him.

“Hey, get offa me, you walruses!” groaned Sam as the two other miners tried to pry Plapp from their comrade. For some minutes the slugging, kicking mass rolled over and over on the ground. Fists flew. Blows were given and taken. The men hardly knew whom they were striking, friend or foe.

Sam felt a hairy hand reach for his throat. He tried to twist out of reach and as he turned someone’s bloody thumb started to gouge his eye out. He sensed rather than saw that Plapp was apparently out of the fight.

“Hey, Plapp!” he shouted, “Where are you, Plapp? They’re killin me, Plapp, pickin’ on a little guy like me!”

For once Plapp’s aid was not forthcoming. Sam fought like a demon, all the while cursing and calling for his fireman. Suddenly it dawned on him that something must have happened to Plapp. “Mebbe they licked him,” he muttered, and redoubled his efforts.

But the gamest fighter in the world couldn’t have held out long against such odds. Three men to one scrapping peewee. They rained blows on him till he ached all over and when he closed his eyes everything spun around and went black. Spitting out teeth, wiping blood from his face, Sam pulled himself together for a last effort.

Suddenly the blows ceased. Shots filled the gully. Two of the claim-jumpers started to run. As the third started to follow them Sam reached out and clutched at a corduroy-trousered leg. He hung on, though he was dragged twenty yards before his prisoner came to a halt at the sharp command, “Stick ’em up.”

Sam lifted his head weakly. “I got him, Plapp!” he murmured. Then he looked around him. Plapp wasn’t there. Just a whole crowd of passengers from his train. He recognized the conductor and some trainmen.

“You done a good job there, little fella,” said one of the miners, coming over and helping Sam to his feet. “These birds have been jumpin’ claims all over the Kougarok. The marshal will be mighty glad to see them.”

“Yeh,” said Sam without interest. “Where’s Plapp?”

The man pointed toward another group of people a few yards away. “You mean the fireman? Oh, he’ll pull through. The doc is lookin’ after him.”

“The doc!” Sam screamed, “Plapp! Hey, Plapp!”

While some of the miners marched the claim-jumpers back to the train, Sam dashed over toward those who had gathered around Plapp. "What's the matter, doc?" he shouted.

"Nothing serious. Three flesh wounds. Various parts of his anatomy. He says he got them when the fight started. When the big fellow pulled the gun on him first."

"Well, I'll— Hey, Plapp, you're aces. Press the flesh, kid."

The fireman, weak from loss of blood, held out a limp hand and tried to sit up. Willing hands braced his back.

"Them dirty skunks," mumbled Plapp, "tryin' to steal a claim from a little runt like you."

"Yeh," agreed Sam slowly, "You fixed 'em. But they made a liar out o' me. Guess my no stop-over record is plumb shot to hell now."

Suddenly the rumble of a train held everybody spellbound. It was coming north bound, up the tracks towards the Kougarok. With a roar it thundered around the bend and rocked past the deserted Nome express, safe on the siding.

Sam looked up blankly. The conductor was standing beside him. "What in blazes?" he exclaimed, "We ain't got a meet at this turn-out." He pulled his orders from his inside pocket and scanned them carefully. "That was a two-car special too."

"That meet?" Sam said. "Yeah, I got it orally from the operator at Ptarmigan Gulch. Forgot to tell you."

The conductor grunted skeptically. He remembered distinctly that Sam had not left his engine cab at Ptarmigan Gulch at all. Nor had the operator come out to the train. However, he said nothing.

The doctor looked up. "If a couple of you boys will give me a hand, I think this man can get back to the train now." Plapp, his head swathed in improvised bandages, hobbled back to the train supported on the willing shoulders of two miners.

Sam climbed into his cab and backed onto the main line carefully. With a trainman firing for him in place of Plapp who was back in one of the passenger coaches, Sam picked his way cautiously down to Moonglow, the

next telegraph station. He beat the conductor by half a length to the telegraph operator's desk, and crashed into a little knot of men who had rushed toward the door upon the arrival of the express. Foremost of these was the general superintendent himself.

"Tebbetts," he said sternly, "where's that northbound special? We were just going out to get the wrecker ready."

"Met her on the turn out at Cooley's Bend."

"Hmm," the super turned to the Moonglow operator. "That man at Ptarmigan Gulch must be drunk. Give me that last wire of his again." The operator handed over a piece of yellow paper, from which the super read aloud:

"Order to have Nome Express wait for special at C. B. turn-out received too late. Nome express left here six minutes ago. Eleven forty-eight."

Sam paled slightly as the superintendent looked him squarely in the eye.

"Tebbetts, did you run into that turn-out on instructions, or did you just have a hunch you'd like to go prospecting again?"

"Yes, sir," said Sam.

"Yes, what? Did you get the orders for that meet with the special?" The super's eyes seemed to bore through to the back of Sam's aching head.

"No, sir," he admitted quietly.

"I thought not. Tebbetts, I told you before about those stop-overs. In this case you happened to be fortunate. Avoided a wreck probably. But you must run according to orders. I'm sorry. I'll have to punish you as I said I would for that non-scheduled stop-over. You're fired."

"Yes, sir," replied Sam, edging slowly towards the door. "But can I finish the run? I'd like to get Plapp down to Nome first, to the hospital."

The super relaxed. "You may." Tebbetts started back to his train.

"Wait a minute," called the super, "I haven't finished yet. I told you we couldn't have a man on this line that persists in prospecting on his runs. Still, you avoided a wreck. You probably saved the lives of many men. We can't afford to lose a man like you, either. After you get into Nome, come around in the morning. Come into my office. I'll give you another run. But first you'll get a two weeks' vacation with pay, to work on that claim of

yours at the bend. Of course you'll have to cut out stop-overs. No pledge, or promise, or anything like that. Just your word, Tebbetts."

"Okay. Press the flesh."

And to Sam's surprise the superintendent gripped his palm.

Transcriber's Note: This story appeared in the May 5, 1929 issue of *Argosy All-Story Weekly*.

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK NO STOP-OVERS

Updated editions will replace the previous one—the old editions will be renamed.

Creating the works from print editions not protected by U.S. copyright law means that no one owns a United States copyright in these works, so the Foundation (and you!) can copy and distribute it in the United States without permission and without paying copyright royalties. Special rules, set forth in the General Terms of Use part of this license, apply to copying and distributing Project Gutenberg™ electronic works to protect the PROJECT GUTENBERG™ concept and trademark. Project Gutenberg is a registered trademark, and may not be used if you charge for an eBook, except by following the terms of the trademark license, including paying royalties for use of the Project Gutenberg trademark. If you do not charge anything for copies of this eBook, complying with the trademark license is very easy. You may use this eBook for nearly any purpose such as creation of derivative works, reports, performances and research. Project Gutenberg eBooks may be modified and printed and given away—you may do practically ANYTHING in the United States with eBooks not protected by U.S. copyright law. Redistribution is subject to the trademark license, especially commercial redistribution.

START: FULL LICENSE

THE FULL PROJECT GUTENBERG™ LICENSE

PLEASE READ THIS BEFORE YOU DISTRIBUTE OR USE THIS WORK

To protect the Project Gutenberg™ mission of promoting the free distribution of electronic works, by using or distributing this work (or any other work associated in any way with the phrase “Project Gutenberg”), you agree to comply with all the terms of the Full Project Gutenberg License available with this file or online at www.gutenberg.org/license.

Section 1. General Terms of Use and Redistributing Project Gutenberg electronic works

1.A. By reading or using any part of this Project Gutenberg electronic work, you indicate that you have read, understand, agree to and accept all the terms of this license and intellectual property (trademark/copyright) agreement. If you do not agree to abide by all the terms of this agreement, you must cease using and return or destroy all copies of Project Gutenberg electronic works in your possession. If you paid a fee for obtaining a copy of or access to a Project Gutenberg electronic work and you do not agree to be bound by the terms of this agreement, you may obtain a refund from the person or entity to whom you paid the fee as set forth in paragraph 1.E.8.

1.B. “Project Gutenberg” is a registered trademark. It may only be used on or associated in any way with an electronic work by people who agree to be bound by the terms of this agreement. There are a few things that you can do with most Project Gutenberg electronic works even without complying with the full terms of this agreement. See paragraph 1.C below. There are a lot of things you can do with Project Gutenberg electronic works if you follow the terms of this agreement and help preserve free future access to Project Gutenberg electronic works. See paragraph 1.E below.

1.C. The Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation (“the Foundation” or PGLAF), owns a compilation copyright in the collection of Project Gutenberg electronic works. Nearly all the individual works in the collection are in the public domain in the United States. If an individual

work is unprotected by copyright law in the United States and you are located in the United States, we do not claim a right to prevent you from copying, distributing, performing, displaying or creating derivative works based on the work as long as all references to Project Gutenberg are removed. Of course, we hope that you will support the Project Gutenberg mission of promoting free access to electronic works by freely sharing Project Gutenberg works in compliance with the terms of this agreement for keeping the Project Gutenberg name associated with the work. You can easily comply with the terms of this agreement by keeping this work in the same format with its attached full Project Gutenberg License when you share it without charge with others.

1.D. The copyright laws of the place where you are located also govern what you can do with this work. Copyright laws in most countries are in a constant state of change. If you are outside the United States, check the laws of your country in addition to the terms of this agreement before downloading, copying, displaying, performing, distributing or creating derivative works based on this work or any other Project Gutenberg work. The Foundation makes no representations concerning the copyright status of any work in any country other than the United States.

1.E. Unless you have removed all references to Project Gutenberg:

1.E.1. The following sentence, with active links to, or other immediate access to, the full Project Gutenberg License must appear prominently whenever any copy of a Project Gutenberg work (any work on which the phrase “Project Gutenberg” appears, or with which the phrase “Project Gutenberg” is associated) is accessed, displayed, performed, viewed, copied or distributed:

This eBook is for the use of anyone anywhere in the United States and most other parts of the world at no cost and with almost no restrictions whatsoever. You may copy it, give it away or re-use it under the terms of the Project Gutenberg™ License included with this eBook or online at www.gutenberg.org. If you are not located in the United States, you will have to check the laws of the country where you are located before using this eBook.

1.E.2. If an individual Project Gutenberg electronic work is derived from texts not protected by U.S. copyright law (does not contain a notice indicating that it is posted with permission of the copyright holder), the work can be copied and distributed to anyone in the United States without paying any fees or charges. If you are redistributing or providing access to a work with the phrase “Project Gutenberg” associated with or appearing on the work, you must comply either with the requirements of paragraphs 1.E.1 through 1.E.7 or obtain permission for the use of the work and the Project Gutenberg trademark as set forth in paragraphs 1.E.8 or 1.E.9.

1.E.3. If an individual Project Gutenberg electronic work is posted with the permission of the copyright holder, your use and distribution must comply with both paragraphs 1.E.1 through 1.E.7 and any additional terms imposed by the copyright holder. Additional terms will be linked to the Project Gutenberg License for all works posted with the permission of the copyright holder found at the beginning of this work.

1.E.4. Do not unlink or detach or remove the full Project Gutenberg License terms from this work, or any files containing a part of this work or any other work associated with Project Gutenberg.

1.E.5. Do not copy, display, perform, distribute or redistribute this electronic work, or any part of this electronic work, without prominently displaying the sentence set forth in paragraph 1.E.1 with active links or immediate access to the full terms of the Project Gutenberg License.

1.E.6. You may convert to and distribute this work in any binary, compressed, marked up, nonproprietary or proprietary form, including any word processing or hypertext form. However, if you provide access to or distribute copies of a Project Gutenberg work in a format other than “Plain Vanilla ASCII” or other format used in the official version posted on the official Project Gutenberg website (www.gutenberg.org), you must, at no additional cost, fee or expense to the user, provide a copy, a means of exporting a copy, or a means of obtaining a copy upon request, of the work in its original “Plain Vanilla ASCII” or other form. Any alternate format

must include the full Project Gutenberg License as specified in paragraph 1.E.1.

1.E.7. Do not charge a fee for access to, viewing, displaying, performing, copying or distributing any Project Gutenberg works unless you comply with paragraph 1.E.8 or 1.E.9.

1.E.8. You may charge a reasonable fee for copies of or providing access to or distributing Project Gutenberg electronic works provided that:

- You pay a royalty fee of 20% of the gross profits you derive from the use of Project Gutenberg works calculated using the method you already use to calculate your applicable taxes. The fee is owed to the owner of the Project Gutenberg trademark, but he has agreed to donate royalties under this paragraph to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation. Royalty payments must be paid within 60 days following each date on which you prepare (or are legally required to prepare) your periodic tax returns. Royalty payments should be clearly marked as such and sent to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation at the address specified in Section 4, "Information about donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation."
- You provide a full refund of any money paid by a user who notifies you in writing (or by e-mail) within 30 days of receipt that s/he does not agree to the terms of the full Project Gutenberg™ License. You must require such a user to return or destroy all copies of the works possessed in a physical medium and discontinue all use of and all access to other copies of Project Gutenberg™ works.
- You provide, in accordance with paragraph 1.F.3, a full refund of any money paid for a work or a replacement copy, if a defect in the electronic work is discovered and reported to you within 90 days of receipt of the work.
- You comply with all other terms of this agreement for free distribution of Project Gutenberg™ works.

1.E.9. If you wish to charge a fee or distribute a Project Gutenberg™ electronic work or group of works on different terms than are set forth in this agreement, you must obtain permission in writing from the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, the manager of the Project Gutenberg™ trademark. Contact the Foundation as set forth in Section 3 below.

1.F.

1.F.1. Project Gutenberg volunteers and employees expend considerable effort to identify, do copyright research on, transcribe and proofread works not protected by U.S. copyright law in creating the Project Gutenberg™ collection. Despite these efforts, Project Gutenberg™ electronic works, and the medium on which they may be stored, may contain “Defects,” such as, but not limited to, incomplete, inaccurate or corrupt data, transcription errors, a copyright or other intellectual property infringement, a defective or damaged disk or other medium, a computer virus, or computer codes that damage or cannot be read by your equipment.

1.F.2. LIMITED WARRANTY, DISCLAIMER OF DAMAGES - Except for the “Right of Replacement or Refund” described in paragraph 1.F.3, the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, the owner of the Project Gutenberg™ trademark, and any other party distributing a Project Gutenberg™ electronic work under this agreement, disclaim all liability to you for damages, costs and expenses, including legal fees. YOU AGREE THAT YOU HAVE NO REMEDIES FOR NEGLIGENCE, STRICT LIABILITY, BREACH OF WARRANTY OR BREACH OF CONTRACT EXCEPT THOSE PROVIDED IN PARAGRAPH 1.F.3. YOU AGREE THAT THE FOUNDATION, THE TRADEMARK OWNER, AND ANY DISTRIBUTOR UNDER THIS AGREEMENT WILL NOT BE LIABLE TO YOU FOR ACTUAL, DIRECT, INDIRECT, CONSEQUENTIAL, PUNITIVE OR INCIDENTAL DAMAGES EVEN IF YOU GIVE NOTICE OF THE POSSIBILITY OF SUCH DAMAGE.

1.F.3. LIMITED RIGHT OF REPLACEMENT OR REFUND - If you discover a defect in this electronic work within 90 days of receiving it, you

can receive a refund of the money (if any) you paid for it by sending a written explanation to the person you received the work from. If you received the work on a physical medium, you must return the medium with your written explanation. The person or entity that provided you with the defective work may elect to provide a replacement copy in lieu of a refund. If you received the work electronically, the person or entity providing it to you may choose to give you a second opportunity to receive the work electronically in lieu of a refund. If the second copy is also defective, you may demand a refund in writing without further opportunities to fix the problem.

1.F.4. Except for the limited right of replacement or refund set forth in paragraph 1.F.3, this work is provided to you ‘AS-IS’, WITH NO OTHER WARRANTIES OF ANY KIND, EXPRESS OR IMPLIED, INCLUDING BUT NOT LIMITED TO WARRANTIES OF MERCHANTABILITY OR FITNESS FOR ANY PURPOSE.

1.F.5. Some states do not allow disclaimers of certain implied warranties or the exclusion or limitation of certain types of damages. If any disclaimer or limitation set forth in this agreement violates the law of the state applicable to this agreement, the agreement shall be interpreted to make the maximum disclaimer or limitation permitted by the applicable state law. The invalidity or unenforceability of any provision of this agreement shall not void the remaining provisions.

1.F.6. INDEMNITY - You agree to indemnify and hold the Foundation, the trademark owner, any agent or employee of the Foundation, anyone providing copies of Project Gutenberg™ electronic works in accordance with this agreement, and any volunteers associated with the production, promotion and distribution of Project Gutenberg™ electronic works, harmless from all liability, costs and expenses, including legal fees, that arise directly or indirectly from any of the following which you do or cause to occur: (a) distribution of this or any Project Gutenberg work, (b) alteration, modification, or additions or deletions to any Project Gutenberg work, and (c) any Defect you cause.

Section 2. Information about the Mission of Project Gutenberg

Project Gutenberg is synonymous with the free distribution of electronic works in formats readable by the widest variety of computers including obsolete, old, middle-aged and new computers. It exists because of the efforts of hundreds of volunteers and donations from people in all walks of life.

Volunteers and financial support to provide volunteers with the assistance they need are critical to reaching Project Gutenberg's goals and ensuring that the Project Gutenberg collection will remain freely available for generations to come. In 2001, the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation was created to provide a secure and permanent future for Project Gutenberg and future generations. To learn more about the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation and how your efforts and donations can help, see Sections 3 and 4 and the Foundation information page at www.gutenberg.org.

Section 3. Information about the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation

The Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation is a non-profit 501(c)(3) educational corporation organized under the laws of the state of Mississippi and granted tax exempt status by the Internal Revenue Service. The Foundation's EIN or federal tax identification number is 64-6221541. Contributions to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation are tax deductible to the full extent permitted by U.S. federal laws and your state's laws.

The Foundation's business office is located at 41 Watchung Plaza #516, Montclair NJ 07042, USA, +1 (862) 621-9288. Email contact links and up to date contact information can be found at the Foundation's website and official page at www.gutenberg.org/contact

Section 4. Information about Donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation

Project Gutenberg™ depends upon and cannot survive without widespread public support and donations to carry out its mission of increasing the number of public domain and licensed works that can be freely distributed in machine-readable form accessible by the widest array of equipment including outdated equipment. Many small donations (\$1 to \$5,000) are particularly important to maintaining tax exempt status with the IRS.

The Foundation is committed to complying with the laws regulating charities and charitable donations in all 50 states of the United States. Compliance requirements are not uniform and it takes a considerable effort, much paperwork and many fees to meet and keep up with these requirements. We do not solicit donations in locations where we have not received written confirmation of compliance. To SEND DONATIONS or determine the status of compliance for any particular state visit www.gutenberg.org/donate.

While we cannot and do not solicit contributions from states where we have not met the solicitation requirements, we know of no prohibition against accepting unsolicited donations from donors in such states who approach us with offers to donate.

International donations are gratefully accepted, but we cannot make any statements concerning tax treatment of donations received from outside the United States. U.S. laws alone swamp our small staff.

Please check the Project Gutenberg web pages for current donation methods and addresses. Donations are accepted in a number of other ways including checks, online payments and credit card donations. To donate, please visit: www.gutenberg.org/donate.

Section 5. General Information About Project Gutenberg electronic works

Professor Michael S. Hart was the originator of the Project Gutenberg concept of a library of electronic works that could be freely shared with anyone. For forty years, he produced and distributed Project Gutenberg eBooks with only a loose network of volunteer support.

Project Gutenberg eBooks are often created from several printed editions, all of which are confirmed as not protected by copyright in the U.S. unless a copyright notice is included. Thus, we do not necessarily keep eBooks in compliance with any particular paper edition.

Most people start at our website which has the main PG search facility:
www.gutenberg.org.

This website includes information about Project Gutenberg, including how to make donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, how to help produce our new eBooks, and how to subscribe to our email newsletter to hear about new eBooks.